

DEAR _____: A LETTER TO A LOST LOVED ONE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Express feelings connected with the loss of a loved one.
2. Clarify thoughts, feelings, and experiences surrounding the lost loved one.
3. Begin a healthy grieving process for the loss of a significant other.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Depression
- Intimate Relationship Conflicts
- Phase of Life Problems
- Vocational Stress

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Traumatic loss can take many forms: death of a loved one, loss of a job, divorce from a loved one, breakup of a significant relationship, loss of a friend, loss of a significant other to a debilitating medical condition, and so on. This letter can be appropriately written and adapted to any of these types of loss as the feelings of grief attached to these losses are similar in many respects. The client is first asked to respond to a series of questions before actually writing the letter to the lost loved one. These questions are designed to help organize his/her thoughts and clarify his/her feelings. After the client responds to the questions, he/she can then begin writing the actual letter. Instruct the client to bring the letter to the following therapy session for processing. It may be helpful to ask the client to read the letter to you to allow for more expression of affect. Allow the client to elaborate on any of the aspects of the letter that you feel are important and tied to unresolved grief issues.

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Writing letters can be a way to help you identify and express your thoughts and feelings. This is especially true when you need to work through your feelings surrounding the loss of an important person in your life. In this homework assignment, you are asked to write a letter to the lost loved one to help you identify and express your own feelings about the significant loss in your life.

1. First, find a quiet or relaxing place where you can write the letter. This will help you concentrate on writing down your thoughts and feelings without distractions. Perhaps you can write the letter in a quiet room in your house, at the library, or in a favorite outdoor place such as a park or beach.
2. Respond to the following questions designed to help you organize your thoughts and feelings before you begin to actually write the letter. You may find that some of these questions do not apply to you; therefore, leave those items blank. Space is also provided for you to express any additional thoughts or feelings that you may want to include in your letter. Feel free to write down whatever thoughts come into your mind at this stage in the assignment. You can decide later as to whether you want to include these thoughts in your final letter.
 - A. What thoughts and feelings did you experience when you learned of the loss of your loved one?

- B. What are some of the positive things you miss about your loved one?

- C. What are some of the hurts, problems, or disappointments that you had in your relationship with your loved one?

D. It is not uncommon to experience guilt or remorse about not having said or done something with a person before the relationship ended. What, if anything, do you wish you could have said or done?

E. Do you feel that the loss of your loved one was in any way your fault? If so, please describe why you feel responsible.

F. Are you sorry about some of the things that happened between you and your loved one? Describe.

G. How has the death of your loved one affected your present life?

H. What are some of the important events that have occurred since the loss of your loved one that you would have liked to have shared with him/her?

I. What fond memories of your loved one do you cherish?

J. How do you feel about your loved one today?

K. How would your loved one want you to live your life now?

L. How do you feel about your life now? What is good and bad about your life now?

M. Use the following space to express any other thoughts or feelings that you would like to include in the letter.

3. Next, review your responses and begin to write the letter. Use the following space or write on separate paper. Bring the completed letter to your next therapy session to discuss with your therapist. After discussing the letter, consider what you would like to do with the letter—do you want to destroy it or throw the letter away? Your therapist can help you answer these questions.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.